PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #45 · ANXIETY

“Not knowing what will happen means something is wrong.”

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Where it often comes from

Some minds treat a blank space as a threat. If the test result is not back, the text is unanswered, or next year is unclear, anxiety fills the blank with “something is wrong.” Uncertainty was often punished in childhood, or a surprise once really was bad news. The lie upgrades “I do not know yet” into “it must be bad.” Not knowing is uncomfortable. It is also ordinary.

What Scripture teaches

God asks for trust precisely where understanding runs out. “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding.” He keeps in peace the mind that is steadfast because it trusts. Jesus says not to worry about tomorrow. Peace that surpasses understanding guards the heart when we pray instead of demanding a preview. God is a refuge in trouble, including the trouble of not knowing. Uncertainty is not a diagnosis.

> *“Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight”* (Proverbs 3:5–6).

Also see

> “Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own” (Matthew 6:34).

> “You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You” (Isaiah 26:3).

> “Be anxious for nothing, but in everything, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus” (Philippians 4:6–7).

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” (Psalm 46:1).

Common self-statements

- If I do not know, it is bad.
- I cannot rest until I know.
- Silence means something is wrong.
- Other people can tolerate mystery. I cannot.
- I have to keep searching until the feeling stops.
- God would not leave me without an answer if things were all right.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Filling an unknown with a bad ending.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unsettled by mystery and calling the mystery a problem.
- Catastrophizing: Turning “not yet” into “something terrible.”
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either I know everything or nothing is safe.

Challenging questions

- What fact am I missing, and what story have I put in its place?

- Has “I don’t know yet” turned out all right before?
- What would waiting for the real answer look like?
- Am I asking God for peace, or for a preview?
- What do I actually need to know today?
- Who could help me wait without refreshing the fear?

Truth summary

> Not knowing the future is normal. Uncertainty is not the same as something being wrong. I can trust God with what I cannot see.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Anxiety/Worry
- Trust
- Peace
- Thinking, Healthy
- Faith

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Thinking, Healthy
- Truth

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God sees the road you cannot see yet.

Jesus — Chris Tomlin
Jesus is present in what you do not understand.

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
Following God does not require control of every outcome.

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
You can bring the unknown to God in plain prayer.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Not knowing what will happen means something is wrong."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Not knowing what will happen means something is wrong." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What fact am I missing, and what story have I put in its place?
- ☐ Has "I don't know yet" turned out all right before?
- ☐ What would waiting for the real answer look like?
- ☐ Am I asking God for peace, or for a preview?
- ☐ What do I actually need to know today?
- ☐ Who could help me wait without refreshing the fear?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Not knowing the future is normal. Uncertainty is not the same as something being wrong. I can trust God with what I cannot see.
- ☐ A blank space is not bad news.
- ☐ I can wait for facts without inventing them.
- ☐ God sees what I do not.
- ☐ Peace does not require a full preview.
- ☐ I can pray about the unknown instead of filling it with fear.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Proverbs 3:5–6
  "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."
- ☐ Matthew 6:34
  "Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own."
- ☐ Isaiah 26:3
  "You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When not knowing felt like bad news: Each day, write down one moment when a blank felt dangerous. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 3:5 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I do not have to understand this yet. I can trust the Lord with it.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Write the unknown and the story. Two lines: what you do not know, and the ending you invented. Cross out the invented ending until there is news.
- ☐ Delay one check. Wait a set time before refreshing the email, the portal, or the text that is feeding the fear.
- ☐ Pray the unknown in one sentence each morning instead of demanding the outcome.
- ☐ Do today's task that does not depend on the answer you are waiting for.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Not knowing what will happen means something is wrong.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	An unknown I did not fill with fear
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Not knowing what will happen means something is wrong~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I treat every unknown as bad news. Teach me to trust You where I cannot see, and to wait for facts instead of fearing a story. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.